

# VibePick - Privacy Policy

## 1. Introduction

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VibePick is a mood-aware movie recommendation platform developed as part of an academic thesis project at a higher education institution within the European Union. It is committed to protecting your personal information and your right to privacy.

This Privacy Policy explains what information is collected when you use VibePick, how it is used, with whom it is shared, what rights you have in relation to it, and how you can exercise those rights. Please read this document carefully.

By creating an account and using VibePick, you acknowledge that you have read and understood this Privacy Policy.

## 2. Data Controller

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For the purposes of the General Data Protection Regulation (EU) 2016/679 ("GDPR"), the data controller is the VibePick project author, operating under the auspices of the relevant academic institution. The controller determines the purposes and means of processing your personal data.

As this platform is currently in an academic research and prototype phase, the data controller responsibilities are held by the thesis author. Contact for data protection matters should be directed through the institutional channels provided in the accompanying thesis documentation.

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## 3. Data We Collect

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Only the data necessary to provide, improve, and analyse the VibePick service is collected. No data beyond what is described in this section is collected.

| Category        | Data Collected                                                     | Purpose                                      |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Account         | Full name, email address, password (hashed)                        | Authentication, personalisation              |
| Preferences     | Favourite genres, selected streaming platforms                     | Recommendation engine input                  |
| Mood Logs       | Mood category, timestamp, optional text                            | Core recommendation logic, research analysis |
| Activity        | Films marked as watched, wishlist additions/removals, film clicks  | History-aware recommendations, research      |
| Ratings         | Star rating (1–5) of recommendation helpfulness, timestamp         | Recommendation quality research              |
| Recommendations | Films shown, scores used, mode (baseline / mood-aware), session ID | Algorithm evaluation and thesis analysis     |
| Technical       | Session tokens (JWT), browser type (implicit), timestamp metadata  | Security, session management                 |

### 3.1 Data You Provide Directly

When you register, you provide your full name, email address, and a password. During onboarding you select your preferred film genres and streaming platforms. Throughout normal use you log moods, mark films as watched or wishlisted, and optionally rate the helpfulness of recommendations.

### 3.2 Data Generated Automatically

When you interact with VibePick, the system automatically records the films displayed to you, the scores used to rank them, the mode under which recommendations were generated (baseline or mood-aware), and timestamped records of your actions. This data is essential for the academic evaluation of the recommendation algorithm.

### 3.3 Data We Do NOT Collect

- Precise geolocation
- Device identifiers or advertising IDs
- Social media profile data
- Payment information (VibePick is free to use)
- Biometric data
- Sensitive personal data as defined under GDPR Article 9

## 4. Legal Basis for Processing

Under the GDPR, we must have a lawful basis for each processing activity. The table below sets out the basis we rely upon for each category of processing.

| Processing Activity                      | Legal Basis          | GDPR Reference |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------|
| Account creation & authentication        | Contract performance | Art. 6(1)(b)   |
| Providing recommendations                | Contract performance | Art. 6(1)(b)   |
| Storing preferences & mood logs          | Consent              | Art. 6(1)(a)   |
| Academic research & algorithm evaluation | Legitimate interests | Art. 6(1)(f)   |
| Security & fraud prevention              | Legitimate interests | Art. 6(1)(f)   |
| Legal compliance                         | Legal obligation     | Art. 6(1)(c)   |

Where VibePick relies on consent as a legal basis, you have the right to withdraw that consent at any time without affecting the lawfulness of processing carried out prior to withdrawal. You may withdraw consent by deleting your account through the "Your Account" page.

## 5. How We Use Your Data

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Your personal data is processed for the following purposes:

1. To provide and operate the VibePick platform, including generating personalised film recommendations based on your current mood, genre preferences, and viewing history.
2. To evaluate and improve the recommendation algorithm, including comparing the effectiveness of mood-aware versus baseline recommendation modes. This analysis forms part of the academic thesis research.
3. To maintain and secure your account, including verifying your identity at login and protecting against unauthorised access.
4. To enable you to manage your personal data, including exporting your data in a portable format or requesting deletion of your account and all associated data.
5. To record and store recommendation session data, including which films were shown to you, the scores used, and any ratings you provided, for the purpose of academic evaluation.

Your data is not used for advertising, marketing to third parties, profiling for commercial purposes, or any purpose incompatible with those listed above.

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## 6. Data Sharing and Third Parties

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VibePick does not sell, rent, trade, or otherwise transfer your personal data to third parties for any commercial purpose. Third-party advertising is not permitted within the VibePick platform.

### 6.1 TMDB (The Movie Database)

VibePick uses the TMDB API to retrieve publicly available film metadata, including titles, descriptions, genre classifications, poster images, and streaming availability information. No

personal user data is transmitted to TMDB. TMDB operates under its own Terms of Use and Privacy Policy, available at [www.themoviedb.org](http://www.themoviedb.org).

## 6.2 Academic Disclosure

Anonymised and aggregated research data derived from platform usage (for example, statistical patterns in mood-to-genre correlations across all users) may be included in the academic thesis and associated publications. No individual user will be identifiable from any published research output.

## 6.3 Legal Requirements

Your personal data may be disclosed if required to do so by applicable law, regulation, or court order, or where such disclosure is necessary to protect the rights, property, or safety of VibePick, its users, or others.

# 7. Data Retention

Your personal data is retained only for as long as necessary for the purposes for which it was collected, or as required by law.

| Data Type                | Retention Period          | Basis                          |
|--------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Account & preferences    | Duration of account       | Contract performance           |
| Mood logs & activity     | Duration of account       | Research / legitimate interest |
| Recommendation sessions  | Duration of account       | Research / legitimate interest |
| Helpfulness ratings      | Duration of account       | Research / legitimate interest |
| Anonymised research data | Up to 5 years post-thesis | Legitimate interest (academic) |

| Data Type     | Retention Period | Basis                          |
|---------------|------------------|--------------------------------|
| Security logs | Up to 90 days    | Legitimate interest (security) |

Upon account deletion, all personal data is permanently removed from the databases, with the exception of anonymised, non-identifiable aggregated research data that may be retained for academic purposes. Deletion is cascaded across all associated records, including mood logs, interactions, watchlists, subscriptions, and recommendation histories.

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## 8. Security

VibePick implements technical and organisational measures designed to protect your personal data against unauthorised access, disclosure, alteration, or destruction. Security measures include:

- Password hashing using bcrypt with an appropriate cost factor, ensuring that plaintext passwords are never stored.
- Authentication via JSON Web Tokens (JWT) with server-side validation on every protected request.
- HTTPS transport encryption for all data in transit between your browser and VibePick's server.
- Parameterised SQL queries throughout the backend to prevent SQL injection attacks.
- Access controls ensuring that users can only access their own data.

While reasonable security measures are employed, no method of transmission over the internet or method of electronic storage is 100% secure. VibePick cannot guarantee the absolute security of your data. In the event of a data breach that is likely to result in a risk to your rights and freedoms, you will be notified and the relevant supervisory authority as required under GDPR Article 33 and Article 34.

## 9. Your Rights Under the GDPR

As a data subject under the GDPR, you have the following rights. These rights may be exercised at any time by using the in-app tools described below, or by contacting VibePick's author through the institutional channels provided.

| Your Right                         | What It Means                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Right of Access (Art. 15)          | You have the right to obtain confirmation of whether we process your personal data, and to receive a copy of that data. Use the "Export My Data" function on the Privacy & Data page.                              |
| Right to Rectification (Art. 16)   | You have the right to have inaccurate personal data corrected. You can update your name, email address, and password at any time via the Your Account page.                                                        |
| Right to Erasure (Art. 17)         | You have the right to request the deletion of your personal data. Use the "Delete Account" function on the Your Account page. Deletion is permanent and irreversible.                                              |
| Right to Portability (Art. 20)     | You have the right to receive your personal data in a structured, machine-readable JSON format. Use the "Export My Data" function on the Privacy & Data page.                                                      |
| Right to Restrict (Art. 18)        | You have the right to request that we restrict the processing of your personal data in certain circumstances.                                                                                                      |
| Right to Object (Art. 21)          | You have the right to object to processing based on legitimate interests. Where we rely on legitimate interests for research purposes, we will consider your objection and respond within the statutory timeframe. |
| Right to Withdraw Consent (Art. 7) | Where processing is based on consent, you may withdraw at any time. This does not affect the lawfulness of prior processing.                                                                                       |

| Your Right                  | What It Means                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Right to Complain (Art. 77) | You have the right to lodge a complaint with a supervisory authority. In Romania this is the National Supervisory Authority for Personal Data Processing (ANSPDCP), at <a href="http://www.dataprotection.ro">www.dataprotection.ro</a> . |

## 9.1 How to Exercise Your Rights

The following in-app tools allow you to exercise your rights directly, without contacting the author:

- Privacy & Data page → "Export My Data" button: downloads a complete JSON export of all your personal data (Right of Access, Right to Portability).
- Your Account page → name, email, and password fields: edit and save at any time (Right to Rectification).
- Your Account page → "Delete Account" button: permanently deletes your account and all associated data (Right to Erasure).

For rights that cannot be exercised through the in-app tools (restriction, objection, complaints), please contact the data controller through the institutional channels provided in the thesis documentation.

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## 10. Cookies and Local Storage

VibePick uses browser localStorage to store your authentication token (JWT) and basic account information (name and email) locally on your device. This information is stored solely to maintain your logged-in session and is not used for advertising or tracking purposes.

Currently no third-party cookies are used, tracking pixels, or analytics SDKs. No data stored in localStorage is shared with third parties.



You may clear your localStorage at any time via your browser's developer tools or settings. Doing so will log you out of the platform.

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